AI IN EDUCATION · PRACTICAL GUIDE

Microsoft Copilot

for teachers and school leaders

A practical guide for schools running Microsoft 365 — which Copilot you're actually using, what enterprise data protection (EDP) gives you, and the six features worth building into the teaching week.

CHAT WRITE SUMMARISE

JOHAN LINDSTRÖM
choosewise.education

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THE GUIDE

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HOW TO READ THIS GUIDE

Part 1 names the single most confusing thing about Microsoft's product: three licence tiers for a work or school account plus a free consumer app, all called "Copilot", with different privacy profiles. Get that straight, then the rest follows. Part 2 is the feature walkthrough — six surfaces that actually land in a teacher's working week, each with classroom examples and a clear note on where the data flows. Part 3 is for anyone responsible for school policy: what enterprise data protection gives you, where the EU Data Boundary applies, how to handle student data, and five concrete decisions to make before a staff rollout.

INTRODUCTION

Why this guide exists

Most schools already run their entire admin stack on Microsoft 365. Copilot is the AI that lives inside that stack. The question isn't whether to adopt it — it's whether to use it the way your tenant already protects, or the consumer way that does not.

Microsoft's naming is the single most confusing thing about this product. A teacher signed in with a personal Microsoft account and a teacher signed in with the school's work or school account have both used "Copilot". They have not used the same product — and they may well have typed the same address to get there, because Microsoft's own documentation says a personal account can reach the Copilot app's primary host too. One path is a consumer service under Microsoft's consumer terms. The other is an enterprise-bounded service covered by the school's existing Microsoft 365 Data Processing Agreement. The prompts they type go to different places with different retention, training, and audit rules attached.

That distinction is not a detail. It is the entire compliance story for Copilot in a school setting, and Microsoft's own marketing does not make it easy to see. The rest of this guide is organised around making it visible — so a teacher can choose deliberately, and a principal can write a policy that the staff will actually follow.

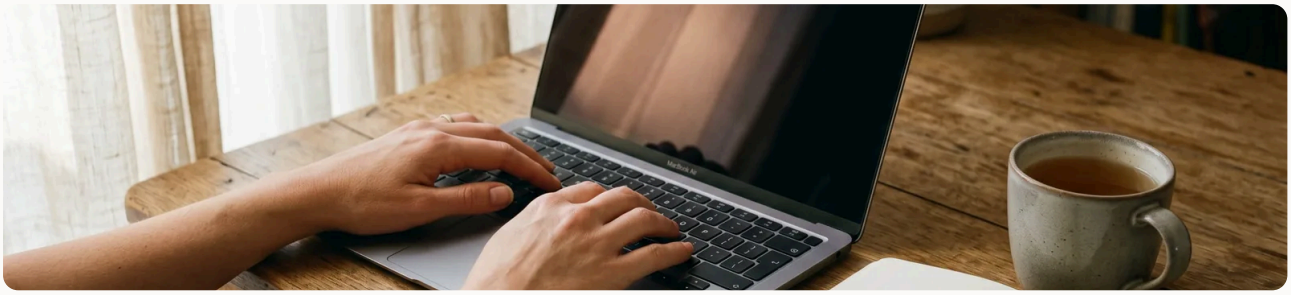
The genuine differentiator for schools is **enterprise data protection** (EDP). When a user signs in with a work or school account, prompts and responses are bounded to the tenant, are not used to train Microsoft's foundation models, and inherit the school's existing data-processing agreement. That is a meaningful privacy posture — and it only applies when the user is signed in to the correct account. Sign-in is compliance. Everything else in Part 3 is a footnote to that sentence.

The voice in this guide is the same as the rest of choosewise.education: calm, adult, practical. It tells you where the product earns its keep in the teaching week, and it is honest where the story breaks. One note before we begin: AI in education is evolving quickly, and the rules that apply to a school differ from place to place. Part 3 carries a short box on the three things you have to check where you work.

PART 1

01 Get started

Which Copilot are you actually using, how to turn the right one on, and what enterprise data protection does and doesn't do.



Which product are you actually using?

What Microsoft sells today is three licence tiers for a work or school account, plus the free consumer app anyone can sign in to with a personal Microsoft account. They are not the same product and they do not have the same privacy profile. This is the table worth printing and pinning somewhere a teacher can glance at it when the interface looks ambiguous. One naming note before you read it: Microsoft has renamed Microsoft 365 Copilot to **Microsoft Copilot** and Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat to **Microsoft Copilot Chat**, while saying that some experiences, licences, and capabilities may keep referencing the old names during the transition — which is why the licence names below are still the ones your admin centre shows.

NAME	WHO IT'S FOR	EDP?	LICENCE & COST
Copilot Chat (Basic)	Anyone at your school signed in with the work or school account	Yes — EDP applies	Included
Microsoft 365 Copilot (Basic)	Staff who need Copilot inside Word, Excel, PowerPoint, OneNote	Yes — EDP applies	No add-on licence needed
Microsoft 365 Copilot (Premium)	Add-on seats: priority access plus grounding in Microsoft Graph and Work IQ	Yes — EDP applies	USD 30.00 user/month, paid yearly
Microsoft Copilot on a personal account	Anyone signed in with a personal Microsoft account (MSA)	No — consumer terms	Free

The practical rule for schools: **sign in with the work/school account** every time. That single behaviour — not the address in the browser bar — is the difference between a teacher's prompt staying inside your Microsoft 365 tenant and the same prompt flowing into a consumer product covered by different terms. Anywhere you see the Copilot icon inside Word, Excel, PowerPoint, or Outlook on a tenant-signed-in device, EDP is already in effect because you are logged into the tenant. That is the easy case. The harder case is the browser, and it is harder than it looks: Microsoft's own documentation says a

personal Microsoft account can reach the Copilot app's primary address as well, so the address cannot tell a teacher which product they are in. The signed-in account can — and inside the Microsoft 365 apps, Microsoft displays an in-product label to help users identify which Copilot experience they are using.

PART 1 · SETUP

Turning it on (teacher-first)

Copilot is not a download you install. It is a server-side capability that appears in the apps you already use once the tenant admin has flipped the right switches and, where the paid add-on tier is involved, assigned the licence to the user.

Microsoft 365 apps (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, OneNote, Teams)

On macOS, iPadOS, and Windows, the Copilot icon appears in the ribbon or the right-hand pane of each app once the tenant is licensed. This is where the picture changed, and it reverses the budgeting advice an earlier edition of this guide gave: Copilot in Word, Excel, PowerPoint, and OneNote no longer requires the add-on licence. A Microsoft 365 Copilot (Basic) licence gives standard access to those four apps; the Premium add-on is what adds priority access and grounding in Microsoft Graph and Work IQ. There is no user-side install. If the icon is not there, either the licence has not been assigned, or the app client has not yet refreshed — signing out and back in usually resolves it.

Microsoft Copilot Chat (included with a work/school account)

The fastest way to try Microsoft Copilot Chat is to open **copilot.cloud.microsoft** in a browser and sign in with your work account, or click the Copilot icon in the Teams sidebar or in the Edge browser's right-hand pane. EDP follows from that sign-in, not from the address — the same host answers to a personal account too. No add-on licence is required: Microsoft's enterprise price list shows Copilot Chat as included.

Mac and personal-device cases

On a personal Mac that needs to handle school work, download the **Microsoft Copilot** app — the one Microsoft used to call the Microsoft 365 Copilot app — from the Mac App Store. It provides a standalone chat surface that still uses the work login, so EDP applies. This is useful for teachers whose school-issued device is a PC but whose home setup is a Mac.

1. Confirm with the tenant admin (or IT lead) which licence tier you are on. Copilot in Word, Excel, PowerPoint, and OneNote is standard access without the add-on; the Premium add-on is what buys priority access and grounding in your tenant's own content.
2. Open Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, or Teams and look for the Copilot icon in the ribbon or right-hand pane.
3. For general chat, visit **copilot.cloud.microsoft** and sign in with the work account, or click the Copilot icon inside Teams.
4. Check the signed-in account at the top right: your school email, not a personal Microsoft account. That is what puts you under EDP, and inside the Microsoft 365 apps the in-product label names which Copilot experience you are in.

> **A WORD ON COPILOT IN A MAC-FIRST STAFFROOM**
> Copilot is desktop- and laptop-first: Windows, Mac, and the web. Phone apps exist but offer a smaller surface area. If your teachers are on iPad, expect a more limited experience than their colleagues on a MacBook or a school-issued Windows laptop.

Enterprise data protection — what it actually is

THREE CLAIMS, THREE HONEST QUALIFICATIONS

Enterprise data protection (EDP) is Microsoft's name for the controls and commitments, under the Data Protection Addendum (DPA) and the Product Terms, that apply to customer data for users of Microsoft Copilot and Microsoft Copilot Chat — the posture you get when a user is signed in with a work or school account. It is the real differentiator for Copilot in an education setting, and it carries three specific, verifiable claims. It also comes with three honest qualifications that a school's own data-protection documentation needs to state plainly.

1. Prompts and responses are not used to train Microsoft's foundation models. Under EDP, the content you type into Copilot and the content Copilot returns are not added to the training data that shapes future models. This is a contractual commitment under the Microsoft Products and Services Data Processing Addendum (DPA), not a marketing line. *Qualification:* this covers Microsoft's own training. It does not cover third-party connectors you or the admin explicitly approve — those operate under their own terms.

2. Data stays within your tenant's trust boundary. Prompts, responses, and any grounding content Copilot references (your OneDrive, SharePoint, Outlook, Teams data) stay inside the logical boundary of your Microsoft 365 tenant. Microsoft acts as a processor under your existing DPA; the school remains controller. *Qualification:* "tenant-bounded" is a logical boundary, not a geographic one. Physical storage may still be in an EU region thanks to the EU Data Boundary, but the claim being made here is about access control, not about data residency.

3. Standard M365 audit and retention rules apply. Copilot interactions are logged under the same audit, eDiscovery, and retention framework you already use for Exchange and SharePoint. If your school has a retention policy on Outlook mail, it applies to Copilot-generated email drafts that were saved. *Qualification:* this also means interactions are subject to lawful access requests under the same framework — EDP is not a cloak of invisibility, it is an existing governance fabric extended to a new surface.

What EDP is not

EDP is a genuine privacy posture. It is also worth being clear about what it does not do — the school's own data-protection documentation will benefit from the precision, and a staff briefing will go better if the language stays honest.

EDP does not eliminate cloud processing. Copilot's responses are generated in Microsoft's cloud, not on your laptop. Nothing about EDP changes the fact that prompts leave the device, are transmitted over the internet, and are processed on Microsoft infrastructure. "On-device" is not part of the Copilot story the way it is for Apple Intelligence.

EDP does not change who is accountable for student data. The school remains the data controller, and Microsoft acts as a processor under the Microsoft Products and Services Data Processing Addendum. What lawful basis you need before processing student data, and what you have to document, is set where you work — the box later in Part 3 says what to check. EDP is a technical and contractual mitigation that makes an existing basis cleaner to defend — it does not manufacture one for you.

EDP does not cover third-party connectors. If the admin approves a plugin or a custom **Microsoft Copilot Studio** agent that reaches into an external system, that integration operates under its own terms. Microsoft's own guidance is to read each agent's privacy statement and terms of use separately. Catalogue every connector; each one is its own line in the school's data-protection documentation.

Where the data is processed. The EU Data Boundary is Microsoft's commitment to store and process customer data for its enterprise online services inside a geographically defined boundary, and for EU customers Copilot is an EU Data Boundary service. Microsoft publishes no percentage for how much that covers; it publishes the exceptions instead — web search queries are not covered by the boundary, models provided by Anthropic as a subprocessor are currently excluded, and a tenant that has purchased Multi-Geo Capabilities is out of scope. Verify which of those touch your tenant with your procurement contact; the list is published and it moves.

THE RULE OF THUMB

Signed in with a work or school account = EDP. Signed in with a personal Microsoft account = no EDP. It is the account that decides it, not the address — the same host answers to both. The rest of this guide assumes you are on the EDP path; Part 3 returns to what that means in practice for school policy.

Worth knowing (but outside this guide's scope)

Two adjacent Copilot products come up in staffroom conversation but sit outside what most teachers and school leaders need to read about before a rollout. One is a project; the other is no longer sold.

Microsoft Copilot Studio

A low-code surface for building custom Copilot agents grounded in your own data — an HR agent, a policy agent, a student-handbook agent. This is IT-department territory, not every-teacher territory, and it carries a cost line of its own: agents are metered, and running them needs an Azure subscription or prepaid Copilot Studio capacity packs. If your school is big enough to have someone in that seat, it is worth an internal session. For the teacher audience this guide is written for, it is a category to know about, not to act on.

Copilot Pro — withdrawn

The paid consumer upgrade that used to sit above the free consumer app. Microsoft has withdrawn it: it is no longer available for purchase, and existing subscribers could keep it only until they cancelled or support ended on 1 August 2026. The consumer line-up Microsoft prices today is Microsoft 365 Personal, Family, and Premium. **It was never relevant for school-issued work, and it is not a live option now.** If a teacher mentions it, the answer is that their school-account Microsoft Copilot Chat already gives them more than enough for school tasks, and keeps EDP.

THE TAKEAWAY FOR PART 1

Three licence tiers carry EDP — Copilot Chat (Basic), Microsoft 365 Copilot (Basic), and the Microsoft 365 Copilot (Premium) add-on — and all three are reached with a work or school account. Copilot signed in with a personal Microsoft account is a separate product family with a separate privacy model. Sign in with the work account, every time, and you land on an EDP path by default; the address you arrived at does not decide it. Part 2 walks through the six features you'll actually use on the EDP path; Part 3 returns to what the policy picture looks like when leadership has to sign off.

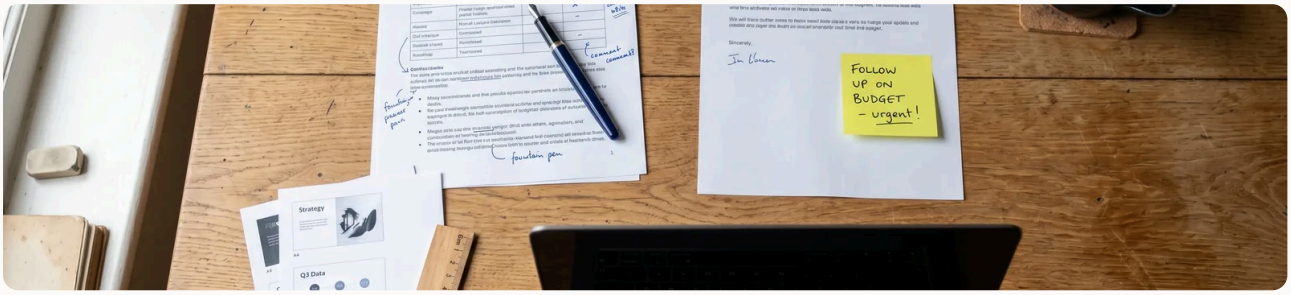
> ONE HABIT WORTH BUILDING
>
> Before you press Enter on any Copilot prompt, check the signed-in account at the top-right of the window. It should be your school email, not a personal Microsoft account — and inside the Microsoft 365 apps, the in-product label tells you which Copilot experience you are in. Wrong account? Sign out and sign back in with the work account. Reopening the same address changes nothing on its own; changing the account is the whole fix.

02

PART 2

Work smarter

Six features that change the teaching week, with classroom examples and a clear note on where each one processes your data.



1. Copilot Chat (with your work data)

General-purpose chat with tenant-bounded EDP. The same kind of conversation surface as Claude or ChatGPT, but signed in to your school's Microsoft 365 tenant and — on the Microsoft 365 Copilot (Premium) add-on — able to reference your own OneDrive and SharePoint files when you anchor a prompt.

Classroom examples

- **Drafting lesson plans from existing material:** with the Premium add-on, type / in the chat and pick last year's OneNote section on photosynthesis. Ask for a refreshed plan for this year's group, with a differentiation column added.
- **Extracting action items from a meeting transcript:** paste a long Teams transcript and ask for a numbered list of commitments by person. A forty-minute meeting becomes a ten-line follow-up in a minute.
- **Summarising a curriculum document:** drop in a twenty-page curriculum module or a school-improvement plan and request a one-page summary pitched for a department briefing.
- **Tone-rewriting a parent email:** paste a terse draft and ask for a warmer version, then a concise version, then one in plain language for a parent who is still learning the school's language of instruction.
- **Scaffolding differentiation ideas:** describe a mixed-ability group and ask for three adjustments at the low-support end and three at the extension end. Treat the output as a starting draft, not the final plan.

> **WHERE IT RUNS · COPILOT CHAT**
> Microsoft cloud. EDP is enabled when you are signed in with the work/school account — so check the account at the top right, not the address. Anchoring a prompt to your own OneDrive or SharePoint files needs the Microsoft 365 Copilot (Premium) add-on, which is the tier that grounds answers in Microsoft Graph and Work IQ; Copilot Chat without it still carries EDP but does not see your tenant's files.

How to start

1. Open **copilot.cloud.microsoft** in a browser and sign in with your school account, or click the Copilot icon in the Teams sidebar or the Edge browser's right-hand pane.
2. Check that the account at the top right of the window is your school account before you start typing.
3. Type your prompt. To reference a specific file (with the Premium add-on), type / and pick the document from OneDrive or SharePoint.
4. Copy the output into Word, Outlook, or wherever you needed it — or ask Copilot to create a Page (see feature 6).

2. Copilot in Word

Draft-from-prompt, rewrite a selection, and summarise a document without leaving the editor. It is not a separate app — it is a pane that slides out of the Home ribbon, and it has access to the document you have open, so its rewrites respect the surrounding context.

Classroom examples

- **Outline to newsletter:** a two-bullet outline ("field trip Friday; money by Wednesday; permission forms out today") becomes a full parent newsletter draft you can trim rather than write.
- **Tone adjustment:** a terse incident report becomes a warmer, more narrative version for a parent-facing summary, without losing the specifics.
- **One-paragraph summary of a long read:** drop a twelve-page research article into Word and ask Copilot for a one-paragraph summary and a bullet list of key points for a staff briefing.
- **Parallel versions in two languages:** useful for EAL parents — the same letter in the school's language and in a family's home language, side by side, checked by you rather than by Copilot alone.

- **Rewriting jargon for students:** paste a paragraph from a technical source and ask for a Year 7 reading-level version that keeps the key concepts intact.

> WHERE IT RUNS · COPILOT IN WORD
> Microsoft cloud. EDP is in effect because Word is signed into the tenant. Copilot in Word is standard access on a Microsoft 365 Copilot (Basic) licence — it no longer sits behind the paid add-on; what the add-on buys is priority access and grounding in your tenant's own content.

How to start

1. Open a Word document signed into your work account.
2. Click the **Copilot** icon in the Home ribbon.
3. Either ask Copilot to draft from a prompt, or select a paragraph and use "Rewrite with Copilot" from the pane.

3. Copilot in Outlook

Summarise long threads, draft replies in a specific tone, and coach your writing before you send. Outlook is where most teachers feel Copilot's daily value first — the inbox is relentless, and the cognitive overhead of reading, replying, and softening parent emails is one of the biggest invisible taxes on the teaching week.

Classroom examples

- **Morning parent triage:** thirty parent emails over the weekend. Copilot's "Summarise" on each thread reveals which three actually need a reply today and which twenty-seven are confirmations, thanks, or FYIs.
- **Catching up on a forty-message thread:** a long back-and-forth between department heads you missed while teaching. Summarise gives you what was decided and what was disputed in three paragraphs.
- **Softening a draft before sending:** the "Coaching" feature reviews a reply for tone and suggests edits before you hit send. Useful for the moment when you realise your draft is sharper than it needs to be.
- **Extracting what you owe:** "Summarise what actions I committed to this week" across the Sent folder — a quick self-audit before the Friday staff meeting.
- **Follow-up after a meeting:** drafting a thank-you-and-confirmation email based on the notes already in the thread, without retyping the specifics.

WHERE IT RUNS · COPILOT IN OUTLOOK

Microsoft cloud. EDP is in effect. Outlook is not on Microsoft's standard-access list — that list is Word, Excel, PowerPoint, and OneNote — but Outlook is not add-on-only either. Without the add-on, Copilot Chat works in Outlook against content you already have open: it is aware of the open item and can use it instead of making you copy, paste, or upload anything. The in-ribbon experience is what the add-on licence buys — drafting emails, summarising threads, and the coaching tips for clarity, sentiment, and tone.

How to start

1. Open Outlook signed into your work account.
2. Click the **Copilot** button in the ribbon, or the sparkle icon inside a compose window.
3. For a thread summary, open any long thread and click "Summarise by Copilot" at the top of the reading pane.

4. Copilot in Teams (meeting recap & in-chat help)

Real-time meeting transcription, post-meeting recap with action items, and in-chat answers about what just happened. For a staff meeting, a department meeting, or a parent-teacher conference, Copilot turns thirty minutes of notes into three minutes of review — provided transcription was enabled and participants were informed.

Classroom examples

- **Action items from a department meeting:** a numbered list of commitments by person, generated from the transcript while people are still putting their coats on.
- **Catch-up for a colleague who missed the staff meeting:** "Summarise what was decided and what is still open" — three minutes instead of half an hour of asking around.
- **Parent-teacher conference recap:** a clean summary of what was discussed, shared back to the parent with agreed next steps. Saves the teacher from typing the same recap ten times across a parents' evening.
- **What did I commit to?** a quick self-audit after a leadership meeting before you move on to teaching the next period.
- **Shared recap for the staff wiki:** one-click generation of a weekly summary for colleagues who were not in the room.

Policy flag: recording and transcripts in Teams must be explicitly enabled — they are not a default. That is a school-policy decision, not a technical one. Part 3 returns to this.

WHERE IT RUNS · COPILOT IN TEAMS

Microsoft cloud. EDP is in effect. Teams works the same way as Outlook: without the add-on, Copilot Chat is available in Teams against content you have open, aware of it and able to use it directly. The meeting features are the licensed experience — summarising a meeting (up to 30 days back), transcribing it, and capturing action items. Recording and transcription must still be explicitly enabled in the meeting — and under school policy, participants must be informed.

How to start

1. Start or join a Teams meeting with recording/transcription enabled (visible to all participants).
2. Open the **Copilot** pane on the right.
3. During the meeting, ask Copilot in-chat questions ("what was just decided?"). After the meeting, ask for action items or a full recap.

5. Copilot in PowerPoint

Generate slides from a Word document or a short outline, rewrite slide copy, and suggest speaker notes. PowerPoint is where the productivity delta is largest for teachers who build their own decks — a lesson-plan text document becomes a first-draft slide deck in under a minute, ready to be edited rather than built from a blank slate.

Classroom examples

- **Lesson plan to deck in two minutes:** a one-page Word outline becomes a twelve-slide first-draft PowerPoint, with titles, bullets, and speaker notes you can refine rather than invent.
- **Speaker notes for a guest-teacher deck:** generate notes for each slide so a covering teacher can step in without losing the thread of the unit.
- **Jargon rewrite:** select a slide heavy with subject terminology and ask for a student-accessible rewrite pitched at the year group you teach.
- **Image ideas:** for each slide, ask for three image suggestions that would support the point. Use your own library or a stock service to source them.
- **Tidy an existing deck:** paste a rough deck from a colleague and ask Copilot to make the formatting, tone, and structure consistent across slides.

WHERE IT RUNS · COPILOT IN POWERPOINT

Microsoft cloud. EDP is in effect. Copilot in PowerPoint is standard access on a Microsoft 365 Copilot (Basic) licence — the add-on is no longer the gate. Grounding the deck in a specific Word file requires the file to be in OneDrive or SharePoint inside your tenant — local files on the desktop do not work for this path.

How to start

1. Open PowerPoint signed into your work account.
2. Click the **Copilot** icon in the Home ribbon.
3. Either "Create presentation from a file" (pick a Word doc from OneDrive) or type a short outline directly into the prompt.

6. Copilot Pages (shared canvas)

A multiplayer, AI-native canvas that sits between a chat and a document. It persists — unlike a disposable chat — and it is collaborative, so a teaching partner or an assistant can edit alongside you. Pages is the feature that changes how team planning and shared resource work feels, once the habit sets in.

Classroom examples

- **Unit outline with a teaching partner:** co-draft a six-week unit across two accounts, with Copilot filling in differentiation ideas and assessment prompts as you go.
- **Shared resource bank:** build a running document of classroom activities by topic. Students can contribute if access is age-appropriate and gated by the admin.
- **Pros-and-cons for a decision:** visualise a curriculum-change discussion as a persistent artifact your department can revisit rather than losing it in a disposable chat history.
- **Teaching-assistant briefing:** draft a short brief in Pages that your TA can then refine with their own observations and send back.
- **School-improvement working group:** a running project notebook for a small team, with Copilot on hand to summarise meetings and draft sections as the work evolves.

WHERE IT RUNS · COPILOT PAGES

Microsoft cloud. EDP is in effect. Reached from any Copilot Chat response via the "Edit in Pages" option. Sharing a Page with someone outside your tenant follows the same sharing rules as any M365 document — set these consciously before distributing.

At a glance

Unlike Apple Intelligence, Copilot does not have an on-device layer. Everything runs in the Microsoft cloud. The privacy question therefore collapses to one binary: is the user signed in with the work/school account, or not? If yes, EDP applies. If no, consumer terms apply.

INSIDE THE TENANT WITH EDP

Copilot Chat (work account) · Copilot in Word · Outlook · Teams · PowerPoint · Pages. All six features in this guide run in Microsoft's cloud under enterprise data protection when the user is signed into the school tenant.

WHAT THE PREMIUM ADD-ON ADDS

Priority access, Chat prompts grounded in your tenant's own content, and the in-app experiences in Outlook and Teams — drafting emails, summarising threads and coaching tone; summarising meetings up to 30 days back, transcribing them and capturing action items. That is what a paid Microsoft 365 Copilot (Premium) seat buys — USD 30.00 user/month, paid yearly, at list price. Copilot in Word, Excel, PowerPoint, and OneNote is no longer behind it: a Microsoft 365 Copilot (Basic) licence gives standard access to those four, and Copilot Chat reaches Teams and Outlook against open content without the add-on. Copilot Chat without the add-on still carries EDP but does not reach into your tenant data.

CONSUMER COPILOT — NOT COVERED BY THIS GUIDE'S COMPLIANCE STORY

Copilot signed in with a personal Microsoft account (MSA). Different terms, no EDP, no tenant bound, no DPA coverage. Treat it as a separate product category — and note that it is the account that lands a user there, not the address, which is why Part 3 argues for tenant restrictions and Conditional Access rather than for blocking a host name.

A habit worth building: when the Copilot surface opens, glance at the top-right. School email on the account? You are in EDP territory. A personal Microsoft account? You are on the consumer product — sign out and sign back in with the work account. Inside the Microsoft 365 apps, the in-product label names the experience for you.

A week in the classroom, composed

Each of the six features is individually modest. Composed across a working week, they change the shape of a teacher's day — in the same direction as Apple Intelligence, but weighted differently. Copilot's strength is inside the productivity stack your school already uses. Its weakness, relative to a general chatbot like Claude or Gemini, is that it is narrower in scope: it is excellent at Microsoft-surface work, and correspondingly less useful for open-ended thinking outside those apps.

The composition looks like this. Open Outlook first thing Monday. Copilot summarises the weekend inbox into "three replies needed, twenty-seven informational." Write the three replies in Word's Copilot pane, with tone adjustments for each family. Join the department meeting in Teams; Copilot keeps the transcript and generates action items while you are still leaving the room. Back at your desk, ask Copilot Chat to draft a differentiation plan for tomorrow's mixed-ability group. Ask PowerPoint's Copilot to turn last week's lesson outline into slides for the guest teacher on Friday. Drop the shared unit-planning document into Pages so your teaching partner can edit alongside you overnight.

None of these are headline moments. All of them together free an hour or two from a typical week — time that belongs to students and to planning rather than to formatting and triage.

THE ONE FEATURE TO START WITH

If you pick only one feature to build a habit around first, pick **Outlook summarisation**. It is the highest-frequency interaction point for most teachers, the privacy story is clean (EDP from the first tap), and the quality improvement on your inbox — from a firehose to a triage list — is the fastest signal you'll get that Copilot earns its keep.

PART 2 · BEFORE YOU READ PART 3

What changes when you put the manager's hat on

Up to this point the guide has addressed the teacher at the classroom level: individual use, individual habit, individual email rewrite or slide-deck generation. That frame is where most staff will meet Copilot first and where the tool earns its daily value. Part 3 steps back and speaks to the director of education, the principal, the digital-lead, and the DPO — the people who have to answer "is this allowed?" before Copilot lands on a hundred staff laptops.

Part 3 addresses six things specifically. First, what enterprise data protection actually gives you — the three contractual claims, the three honest qualifications, and the translation from legalese into something a staff meeting can understand. Second, why sign-in equals compliance: the single biggest point of failure is a teacher drifting onto consumer Copilot by accident. Third, where your data is stored and processed, and which of that an administrator can see and control. Fourth, the licensing landscape in practical terms: which seat does what, what a phased rollout looks like, and the cost conversation for a 200-seat school. Fifth, student data and age limits — Microsoft's own floor of 13 and older for Copilot with work/school accounts, plus the practical case for starting with teacher-only access even when licenses permit student use. Sixth, five concrete policy decisions the digital-lead can carry into a senior-leadership meeting on a single sheet.

If you are a teacher reading this for your own classroom practice, Part 3 is still worth skimming. The sections on sign-in and student data in particular will make your daily defaults clearer. Part 3 is five pages. The five policy decisions at the end are the takeaway; the rest is the reasoning that supports them.

PART 3

03 Compliance & licensing in practice

What enterprise data protection commits Microsoft to inside a school tenant, how licensing actually lands in a school budget, and the five decisions worth taking before a staff rollout.



What EDP actually gives you

Part 1 set out the three contractual claims of enterprise data protection: prompts and responses are not used to train Microsoft's foundation models; data stays within your tenant's trust boundary; standard M365 audit and retention rules apply. What that means contractually is that Microsoft acts as your processor under the Microsoft Products and Services Data Processing Addendum; the school remains the data controller, with all the obligations that role implies.

What that changes in practice: Copilot operations fall inside a governance fabric you already run under your existing Microsoft Volume Licensing terms — the same addendum, the same audit and retention framework, the same processor relationship. That is genuinely easier to account for than adopting a new cloud AI vendor with an agreement of its own. Two things sit outside that fabric and need naming separately: web search, where the search service handles data under its own practices and Microsoft acts as an independent data controller rather than as your processor, and agents, which carry their own privacy statement and terms of use for the school to read one by one.

What EDP does not change: your school is still the data controller, and the basis for any processing of student data is still yours to establish. EDP is a technical and contractual mitigation that makes an existing basis cleaner to evidence. It does not manufacture a basis. Your own data-protection documentation should frame it that way — as a mitigation layer inside an existing governance structure, not as a replacement for the analysis the school is obliged to perform. Which rules set that obligation depends on where you work; the box later in this part says what to check.

The single biggest point of failure

The failure mode worth worrying about most is not Copilot being hacked. It is a teacher using consumer Copilot by accident. Somebody searches "Copilot" in a browser, clicks the first result, types a prompt. The top-right of the window shows the signed-in account as their personal Microsoft Account from years ago — or no account at all. The address gives nothing away either way: Microsoft's own documentation says a personal account can reach the Copilot app's primary host too. That teacher has just used Copilot. They have not used the Copilot covered by your school's DPA. The prompt is now in consumer scope, under consumer terms.

The fix is behavioural and technical. The behavioural fix is a one-sentence staff rule pinned to the wall: **always sign in with the work/school account before you use Copilot.** The cue is the school email on the profile icon at the top right — and, inside the Microsoft 365 apps, the in-product label Microsoft displays to help users identify which Copilot experience they are using. Train staff to check for it every time. Rehearse the check as part of the first-week onboarding, and include a screenshot in the one-page staff guideline.

The technical fix is tenant-level, and it is not a block on an address. Microsoft's own guidance is explicit: do not block the Copilot host name in order to keep personal accounts out, because a personal Microsoft account can reach the same host — and Microsoft neither recommends nor supports managing Copilot through selective domain, URL, IP or network-protocol filtering. What it points to instead is **tenant restrictions v2** together with Conditional Access to control which accounts can sign in, and the Copilot controls in the Microsoft 365 admin centre to decide which Copilot experiences staff see once they are in. Not every school tenant has the licensing tier that exposes every control. Ask your admin what is possible in your specific tenant, and make the decision consciously.

> THE ONE-SENTENCE TRAINING LINE
> **"School email on the profile at the top right. If that isn't there, you're on the wrong Copilot — and the web address won't tell you."** Every staff member should be able to say that sentence from memory.

Where the processing happens

Microsoft's **EU Data Boundary** is a geographically defined boundary inside which Microsoft has committed to store and process customer data and personal data for its enterprise online services. For EU customers, Copilot is an EU Data Boundary service: EU traffic stays inside the boundary, while worldwide traffic can be sent to the EU and to other regions for the language-model processing itself. Microsoft publishes no percentage for how much of a school's traffic that covers. It publishes the exceptions: transfers out of the boundary happen in limited, documented circumstances, web search queries are not covered by it at all, models provided by Anthropic as a subprocessor are currently excluded, and a tenant that has purchased Multi-Geo Capabilities is out of scope even when the tenant itself is listed in an EU or EFTA country.

Two of those exceptions are things an administrator can act on rather than only record. Web-search grounding is a tenant policy — *Allow web search in Copilot*, in the Microsoft 365 admin centre — so a school that would rather prompts did not reach the search service can switch it off. Multi-Geo is a purchase, so procurement can tell you whether your tenant has it. The same Copilot controls decide which Copilot experiences staff and students see at all, including image generation and whether Copilot Chat access is removed; they sit in the Microsoft 365 admin centre and in Cloud Policy, and they can be held with the AI Administrator role rather than a Global Administrator account. Microsoft documents each of them on Microsoft Learn, which is where to verify the current state for your own tenant.

What none of that settles is which rules you have to satisfy. Where data is stored and processed is a product fact, and your agreement and the admin centre will tell you what it is for your tenant. Which data-protection regime governs that processing, and what it asks you to write down, is set by where your school operates — not by the product. This part states the first and deliberately does not state the second; the box later in this part says what to check locally.

IN A STAFF BRIEFING

You will rarely be asked about processing locations by a teacher. You will often be asked "where does my data actually go?" The honest answer is short: "For EU customers Copilot is an EU Data Boundary service, so EU traffic stays inside that boundary. Web search is the exception staff should know about, because a prompt that searches the web leaves for the search service — and the administrator can switch that off. It is documented, and I can show you the page."

Which seat does what

The same tiers from Part 1, revisited with feature-access detail. This is the version of the table worth giving to someone building a budget.

NAME	WHAT IT UNLOCKS	LICENCE & COST
Copilot Chat (Basic)	Tenant-bounded chat with EDP, in the browser and the Teams and Edge sidebars. No grounding in tenant files.	Included
Microsoft 365 Copilot (Basic)	Standard access to Copilot in Word, Excel, PowerPoint, and OneNote — without the add-on licence.	No add-on licence needed
Microsoft 365 Copilot (Premium)	Priority access; answers grounded in Microsoft Graph and Work IQ — your own files, mail, and Teams content; and the in-app Outlook and Teams experiences (email drafting, thread summaries, meeting summarise and transcribe).	USD 30.00 user/month, paid yearly
Microsoft Copilot on a personal account	Consumer chat only. No tenant integration. No EDP. Not covered by the school DPA.	Free

The cost sentence: Microsoft's list price for the add-on tier — the one its enterprise price list still labels Microsoft 365 Copilot — is **USD 30.00 per user per month, paid yearly** on an annual subscription, and a separate licence for a qualifying Microsoft 365 plan is required alongside it. The small-business variant, Microsoft 365 Copilot Business, lists at USD 18.00 per user per month, paid yearly, reduced from USD 21.00. For education, Microsoft publishes no per-seat figure at all: it states that an academic offering is available for faculty, staff, and students aged 13 and older, and that schools buy it through **Enrollment for Education Solutions (EES) or a Cloud Solution Provider (CSP)**. That route, not a list price, is where your school's number comes from — ask your EES contact or your reseller before you build a budget. At 200 staff the add-on is a material line item; at 20 staff it is a modest one.

The rollout pattern that consistently works: **phase it.** Term one: leadership, subject leads, and two or three volunteer teachers. Term two: broader staff on the EDP Copilot Chat path, which is included. Later: Microsoft 365 Copilot (Premium) add-on seats for the staff who measurably gain from priority access and tenant-grounded answers. Avoid the instinct to license the whole staff on day one — and note that Copilot in Word, Excel, PowerPoint, and OneNote does not need the add-on at all, so the phase-two staff already have more than chat. The tenant flip is fast; organisational readiness is not, and a staff that has had three months to absorb Copilot Chat first will use the add-on more intelligently when the licence arrives.

What this means for student access

Microsoft's own floor for Copilot with a work/school account is students aged **13 and older**, aligned with the Microsoft 365 Education terms that most schools already sign. Students under 13 cannot be given direct Copilot access under these terms, even if the admin were willing to enable it. The practical implication: in primary classrooms, teachers use Copilot on their own accounts to prepare materials. Students do not interact with it directly.

For students 13 and over, access is admin-gated. The tenant admin controls which Copilot surfaces students see, under which licensing terms, and with which guardrails. That is a school-policy question, not a technical inevitability. One concrete recommendation that has aged well across schools that rolled out early: **most schools should start with teacher-only access for at least a full term** before enabling student access — even when licenses permit students from day one. The teacher habit has to settle first. The staff guideline has to exist, have been iterated, and be pinned to a wiki everyone uses. Student access on top of an unfinished teacher rollout is how guidance gets lost.

On the content side, the rule is the same as for every cloud AI product: **de-identify student data before any Copilot prompt.** EDP reduces the risk of that data being used in Microsoft's training, but it does not change the school's obligations as data controller. A teacher sending a SEN plan, a safeguarding note, or a grade list through Copilot has still processed sensitive student data. What that requires of the school — a basis, and a record of it — is set by your own data-protection regime, not by EDP.

> WHAT DEPENDS ON WHERE YOU ARE
>
> Three things in this part are set where you work, not by the product. **Your data-protection regime** decides what lawful basis you need before processing student data, and what you must document. **Your rules on student age and consent** decide who may use Copilot at all, and who signs for it — Microsoft's own age floor is a minimum, not a permission slip. **Your school's procurement and approval route** decides who signs the agreement and who must be consulted first. **What does not depend on where you are:** your school remains the data controller for its students' data, and using Copilot does not transfer that responsibility to Microsoft. Check the three above locally before you rely on any specific rule in this part.

Five policy decisions for your school

01 **Require signed-in work/school account for all Copilot use.** Govern it at the tenant, not at the address: Microsoft's own guidance is to use tenant restrictions v2 and Conditional Access to control personal-account sign-in rather than to block Copilot host names, and the Copilot controls in the Microsoft 365 admin centre decide which Copilot experiences staff reach once they are signed in. The single behaviour that prevents almost every Copilot compliance problem is signing in with the right account. Make that the first line of the one-page staff guideline and rehearse it in onboarding.

02 **Document the Copilot paths in your own data-protection documentation.** Three paths need lines: the Microsoft 365 Copilot (Premium) add-on, Copilot Chat with the work account (included with M365), and — if any staff use Copilot on a personal Microsoft account for adult-only tasks — the consumer path as a separately documented, narrower scope. For each one, record which account signs in, what the Microsoft Products and Services DPA covers, and where the processing happens.

03 **Produce a one-page staff guideline on what to paste and what to avoid.** Three accept examples (generalised parent-email rewrites, curriculum module summaries, meeting action-item extraction). Three avoid examples (SEN plans without de-identification, safeguarding notes, any grade data tied to named students). Tailor the examples to your school. Pin to the shared staff wiki and reference in onboarding.

04 **Phase the rollout.** Leadership plus subject leads in term one on Copilot Chat (included with M365). Broader staff onto Copilot Chat in term two. Microsoft 365 Copilot (Premium) add-on seats (USD 30.00 per user per month, paid yearly, at list price) for the staff who measurably need priority access and tenant grounding — don't default to full-staff licensing. Student access only after the policy is stable and the teacher habit is settled. The tenant admin flip is instant; organisational readiness is not.

05 **Build in a termly review.** Microsoft ships Copilot updates monthly. Feature availability, tenant controls, and Microsoft's own documentation on where data is processed all move. A thirty-minute standing entry each term for the digital-lead to skim Microsoft's release notes and update the staff guideline is enough to stop the policy drifting out of date. More than that is unlikely to stick; less than that is how outdated guidance accumulates.

FAQ

Questions teachers ask

Nine of the questions that come up most often from teachers and school leaders working with Microsoft Copilot.

Which version of Copilot should my school actually use?

Copilot Chat with a work/school account for general chat — included with M365, EDP on by default. The Microsoft 365 Copilot (Premium) add-on (USD 30.00 per user per month, paid yearly, at list price; schools buy through EES or a Cloud Solution Provider instead, and Microsoft publishes no education per-seat figure) for staff who measurably benefit from priority access and answers grounded in your tenant's own content. Copilot in Word, Excel, PowerPoint, and OneNote no longer needs the add-on at all. Never Copilot on a personal Microsoft account for school work: different terms, no EDP, not covered by your school's DPA. The rule of thumb is "signed in with the school account equals safe" — the account, not the address.

Do my prompts train Microsoft's AI?

Under enterprise data protection — which applies to Microsoft Copilot and Microsoft Copilot Chat when the user is signed in with a work or school account — no. Prompts and responses are contractually excluded from training Microsoft's foundation models under the Products and Services DPA. Under consumer Copilot on a personal MSA, different terms apply and the consumer privacy statement should be read directly. Sign-in is the difference.

Does Copilot work in languages other than English?

Yes — in a published list of languages. Microsoft states that Copilot is available globally in over 170 markets, and its language support documentation covers every Copilot experience — personal accounts, work or school accounts, and free Copilot Chat — listing which languages are supported for prompts and responses on each account type. Newer features sometimes launch in English first and add other languages in later waves, so check the current list before promising a feature to staff. If a response reads stiff in your language, add a line to the prompt asking Copilot to rewrite it in a natural, professional register — the correction is usually immediate.

Can I use Copilot with student data?

De-identify first. Even with EDP, the school is still the data controller, and sensitive student data (SEN, safeguarding, named grades) needs a basis and a record of it — what exactly, your own data-protection regime decides. Teacher-work content (generalised plans, staff notes, parent-email drafts) is generally fine on the EDP path. Named student data should be de-identified or avoided in the prompt entirely.

How does Copilot compare to Claude or Gemini?

Different tool class. Claude and Gemini are general chatbots for open-ended thinking and research. Copilot is strongest inside the Microsoft 365 productivity stack you already use. Most teachers end up using both: Copilot for in-app and tenant-grounded work where EDP applies, a general chatbot for broader thinking tasks that need a different kind of reasoning surface.

What about Copilot on my personal computer?

Fine for adult productivity when you sign in with the work/school account — the Microsoft Copilot app on macOS or the web version in a browser both give you the EDP path on a personal machine. Not fine for student data on a personal device that is outside the school's MDM, because the device itself is outside the managed perimeter. Keep student work on school-issued devices.

Is Copilot covered by our school's Microsoft DPA?

Microsoft Copilot and Microsoft Copilot Chat, signed in with a work or school account, are covered under the Microsoft Products and Services DPA you already have as part of your M365 agreement — enterprise data protection is defined as the controls and commitments under that addendum and the Product Terms. Copilot on a personal Microsoft account is a separate product under different terms and is not covered. Verify the current DPA version with your procurement contact; Microsoft updates it on a published cadence.

Can I turn off specific Copilot features for certain staff groups?

Yes. The tenant admin can scope features by user group via the Microsoft 365 admin centre and in Cloud Policy — disabling Copilot in Teams for specific groups, restricting Copilot Chat grounding, or gating the feature entirely for specified cohorts. This is how student access is governed in practice, and it is the lever for a phased rollout. Work with your IT lead on the exact policies.

Where do I get help if something goes wrong?

Microsoft's own documentation at *learn.microsoft.com/copilot*; the Microsoft 365 admin centre for tenant-level configuration; your Microsoft reseller or partner for licensing questions. For school-specific policy, data-protection documentation, or staffroom rollout questions, reach out via *choosewise.education*. Do not skip the release-notes check in your termly review — most "something changed" support tickets trace back to a monthly update.

"Sign in with the work account. That one behaviour is the entire compliance story."

— Johan Lindström, October 2026

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